

A FRESH START
INOX CEO Alok Tandon with Vijay Dhar (right)

> **"A majority of people in the Valley have never seen a film on a big screen. Most businesses you do from the head, but some are done from the heart"**
> **– VIJAY DHAR**

that, though he knows that seeing houseful signs at Kashmir's cinema halls is still a distant dream.

BEGINNING AGAIN

On September 20, Lieutenant-Governor Manoj Sinha launched the INOX multiplex, which was followed by an afternoon screening of Aamir Khan-starrer *Laal Singh Chaddha*. The multiplex will be opened to the public on October 1 with the Hrithik Roshan and Saif Ali Khan-starrer *Vikram Vedha* and Mani Ratnam's historical epic *Ponniyin Selvan*. Sinha says the multiplex marks the revival of the movie culture in Kashmir after three decades. After the opening of two multipurpose cinema halls in Pulwama and Shopian on September 18, Sinha announced plans to establish 100-seater cinema halls in every district. "Cinema brings people together. It offers hopes, dreams and inspiration to the youth," he said in his address at the INOX inauguration.

Last year, the government rolled out a new policy to make Jammu & Kashmir an attractive destination for film shoots. Besides easing the process of approvals, it announced several benefits for filmmakers in the form of subsidies, tax incentives, etc. Sinha has also stated that the government plans to establish a film city in the Valley. "The new cinema halls and the ongoing film shoots will renew the bond between Jammu & Kashmir and the Indian film industry," Sinha said at the inauguration on September 20.

Kashmir has long had a deep connection with the Hindi film industry. In 1932, the first cinema hall in the Valley, Kashmir Talkies (later renamed 'Palladium'), opened at Lal Chowk in Srinagar. It was also the backdrop for Prime Minister Jawaharlal Nehru's historic speech on November 2, 1947, where he promised a referendum in the presence of National Conference founder Sheikh Abdullah. For Kashmir's cine-goers, age, gender, socioeconomic status or language were no bars. The 7 pm English film show was a "social gathering", recalls Dhar, who would go around with his friends asking for '25 paisa' just to be able to